

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Tulsi Gabbard resigned as America's director of national intelligence, citing her husband's diagnosis with a rare form of cancer. An anti-interventionist, **Ms Gabbard** has made few public comments on the Iran war. Her statements on Iran's nuclear enrichment programme have diverged from Donald Trump's; in March she assessed that it had not been rebuilt. Her resignation comes as the Trump administration considers renewing strikes against Iran.

A spokesman for **Iran's** foreign ministry said "deep and extensive" differences remained with **America** and that any **deal** over the country's highly enriched uranium "will not reach a conclusion". Pakistani mediators arrived in Tehran on Friday for negotiations. Earlier Marco Rubio, America's secretary of state, told **NATO** allies of Mr Trump's "disappointment" at their response to his campaign in the Middle East.

A federal judge dismissed the Trump administration's criminal case against **Kilmar Abrego Garcia**, an undocumented immigrant who was **mistakenly deported** to El Salvador last year. He was brought back to America in June and charged with people smuggling. The

judge said the prosecution amounted to a “vindictive” response to a ruling that Mr Garcia’s removal had been illegal.

The **Dow Jones Industrial Average**, an American stock index, rose almost 0.6% on Friday, a record high close. The s&p 500 and the NASDAQ indices have also rallied this month, buoyed by [AI enthusiasm](#) and hopes of peace in Iran, despite uncertainty around negotiations. Yields on America’s 10-year Treasury bonds fell to 4.56%.

Mr Trump defended his \$1.8bn “**Anti-Weaponisation Fund**”, saying he was “helping others” and that he “gave up a lot of money” for it. Mr Trump had sued his own government for \$10bn in damages for leaking his tax returns during his first term. Some Republican senators rebelled against the fund, which could [pay out claims to the president’s allies](#), by delaying a vote on an immigration bill.

The European Union’s pharmaceutical regulator approved **Novo Nordisk’s** [weight-loss pill](#), Wegovy, for sale. The recommendation paves the way for it to become the first oral weight-loss treatment available in the bloc, which puts the Danish drugmaker ahead of its American rival, Eli Lilly. Novo launched the pill in America in December after winning approval from American regulators—four months before Lilly did.

Shein, a [Chinese fast-fashion giant](#), acquired **Everlane**, an American clothing-maker, for an undisclosed amount. Once popular for its sustainably made garments and “[radical transparency](#)”, Everlane has floundered in recent years. Shein bought the majority stake of L Catterton, a private-equity firm that had reportedly been searching for a buyer to clear Everlane’s \$90m debt. The sale has upset some environmentally minded shoppers.

Word of the week: Amorphous silica, the substance that gives opals their shimmer. An Israeli startup wants to blast tiny spheres

of it into the stratosphere to dim the sun and [cool the planet](#).



Photograph: Getty Images

An epidemic of responsibility shirking

The 79th World Health Assembly, an annual gathering of health officials, concludes on Saturday. This year's theme—treating public health as the “shared responsibility” of all countries—is particularly salient right now. An unusual spate of [hantavirus cases has been confirmed aboard a cruise ship](#). And [Ebola infections](#) have surged in central Africa.

The contrast between the two outbreaks is stark. The [hantavirus could be contained](#) to the passengers on the ship. The Ebola outbreak began in a remote, conflict-ridden corner of the Democratic Republic of Congo and quickly spread. It has killed at least 139 people and is expected to claim thousands more lives unless [urgent, co-ordinated action](#) is taken. Aid cuts and political problems have prevented that happening. Meanwhile, belying the WHA's stated goal, delegates failed to reach an agreement to share disease data and treatments that would help fight outbreaks. Instead, they took shared responsibility for punting the negotiations into next year.



Photograph: Getty Images

A pretender to Real Madrid's crown appears

On Saturday Enrique Riquelme, a Spanish businessman, is set to file his candidacy to run [Real Madrid](#), perhaps the most prestigious job in European football. He is mounting a rare challenge to the reign of Florentino Pérez (pictured), the 79-year-old construction magnate who has been the club's president for most of the past 25 years. Mr Pérez called an unexpected election for the post on May 11th, a day after Real lost 2-0 to Barcelona, giving their great rivals the Spanish league title.

Real Madrid is a member-owned, non-profit organisation. Its future may thus be in the hands of the 100,000-odd people who pay subs of €179 (\$208) a year. Mr Pérez's influence over the club and its fans is great. But some have grown disillusioned with his once-successful strategy of hoovering up individual star players rather than moulding cohesive teams. Some fans have even begun to boo Kylian Mbappé, its highest-paid player.



Photograph: Bella Spurrier

Something to wine about

Fifty years ago this weekend, the great names and noses of French [wine](#) were invited by Steven Spurrier, an English wine merchant, to judge a blind tasting. He hoped to garner publicity for his shop and wine school in Paris. To mark America's bicentennial, Spurrier had tracked down a few bottles from young, unknown producers in Napa Valley, California, and put them alongside celebrated ones from Bordeaux and Burgundy. To the shock of everyone, Napa's wines won.

The [Judgment of Paris](#) was the shot heard round the wine world. Napa's victory had two Nebuchadnezzar-size effects. First, it sparked demand for Californian wine at home and abroad. The volume of exported bottles of American wine more than quintupled between 1975 and 1980. Second, it inspired confidence in "new world" producers, including Argentina and Australia. Some see it as the most consequential event in the wine world ever. Just don't bring it up to the French.



Photograph: Rob Youngson/Netflix

A man's world?

Damien Sachs, a high-powered executive at an advertising agency (played by Sacha Baron Cohen), thinks he has it all. He lives luxuriously, enjoys crass jokes and relishes in belittling his female colleagues. That is, until he hits his head and wakes up in a world where gender roles have flipped. Here Harry Potter is Harriet, brands have names like Burger Queen and Victor's Secret—and Alex Fox (Rosamund Pike), an employee he taunted, is now his boss.

“Ladies First”, released on Netflix this weekend, is a remake of a French comedy called “I Am Not an Easy Man”. But it is not an easy watch. Many scenes feature men being sexually harassed and getting [cosmetic surgery](#)—including penis filler—while women pass wind and eat burgers. An earnest finale, in which Damien realises the error of his ways, jars with the silly (and dated) tale. Even a star-studded cast cannot save “Ladies First” from finishing last.



Photograph: Reuters

Weekend profile: Gwynne Shotwell, SpaceX's steady hand on the thrusters

Gwynne Shotwell, SpaceX's president and chief operating officer, has one regret about launching Elon Musk's red Tesla Roadster into space in 2018. "Starman should have been Starmam," she told an audience of women engineers that year, referring to the space-suited mannequin reclining in the driver's seat, and "she should have had a ponytail coming out of her helmet". Mr Musk may be the public face of the firm that this week unveiled plans for the [biggest initial public offering ever](#), but Ms Shotwell is its commander.

When Mr Musk asked her to join [SpaceX](#) in 2002, Ms Shotwell almost turned him down. "It felt really risky," she recalls. Ms Shotwell, a mechanical engineer with a master's degree in applied mathematics and a member of America's National Academy of Engineering, was working at Microcosm, a space startup, and found Mr Musk, then a newcomer to the industry, slightly naive. She thought he was underestimating how much he would have to invest, and wouldn't sign on until he committed at least \$50m. She had another wobble when Mr Musk offered to make her president in 2008. "What an idiot I would have been if I had said no," she reflected, before encouraging her audience to "take risks".

Hers paid off. With Ms Shotwell at the controls, SpaceX has rocketed above established companies and left governments on the launch pad. These days it runs Earth's biggest space programme. Nearly 90% of the mass launched to orbit last year travelled on the firm's pioneering re-usable rockets.

Ms Shotwell is also a skilled saleswoman. She secured a contract to fly cargo to the International Space Station for NASA, which helped secure the startup's financial future. Her skills and personality complement those of Mr Musk. Where the billionaire is abrasive, Ms Shotwell is, in the words of Eric Berger, an author who has followed SpaceX, the "velvet glove". There is, though, no shortage of steel behind her cheery smile.

If the IPO is as stratospherically successful as predicted, Ms Shotwell will have little time to rest on her laurels. SpaceX must make its giant Starship rocket work; build NASA a lunar lander; keep its Starlink satellite-internet business growing; and deliver on its claim that space-based data centres are the future of AI. That is not to mention its long-term goal of putting humans on the Moon and Mars. But after 18 years at the top of the famously demanding company, she seems to have plenty of burn left in her.

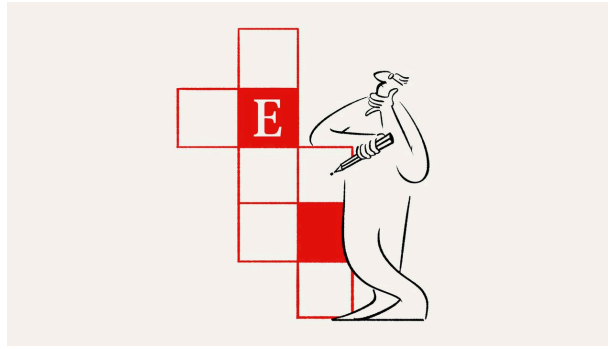


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Add salt to oceans when running (6)

2 across - Tend to throw runes (5)

3 across - Scandinavian minor dictator at heart (6)

1 down - Antagonist misrepresented lack of progress (10)

Straight clues

1 across - Spring; a collection of tv shows (6)

2 across - Caregiver or medic (5)

3 across - Relating to Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway and Sweden (6)

1 down - A period of slow or nonexistent economic growth (10)



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Rob Blair, Harare, Zimbabwe

Lorelei Ritchie, Louisville, Kentucky

Ingo Schwanke, Manitoba, Canada

They all gave the correct answers of: Jackie Chan, Bill Gates, the Hollywood sign, Pulp and dogs. The theme is Quentin Tarantino films: Jackie Brown, Kill Bill (vol 1 and 2), Once Upon A Time In Hollywood, Pulp Fiction and Reservoir Dogs.

The questions were:

Monday: Which martial artist from Hong Kong had a Hollywood hit with the film “Rush Hour”?

Tuesday: Who along with his then wife Melinda, founded one of the world's largest charitable foundations in 2000?

Wednesday: Which famous American landmark had the letters “land” removed in 1949?

Thursday: Jarvis Cocker is the lead singer of which Britpop band?

Friday: Pomeranian, Havanese and Sheltie are breeds of which animal?

*Nature provides exceptions to
every rule.*

Margaret Fuller